

THE LITTLE MAID
OF ISRAEL

EMMA-HOWARD-WIGHT



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The Little Maid of Israel.

BY
Emma Howard Wight.

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THE LITTLE MAID OF ISRAEL.

BY EMMA HOWARD WIGHT.

CHAPTER I.

In the Land of Israel, not a great distance from the city of Samaria, dwelt Ezra with his wife, Sarah, and their two children, Isaac and Leah. The sun was sinking behind the hills as Ezra and Sarah sat before the door of their humble dwelling resting after the labors of the day. On a couch in the doorway reclined a youth with a pale, sickly face and emaciated limbs. Isaac, the eldest-born of Ezra and Sarah, had been a cripple from birth. His eyes, dull and languid from constant pain, tired and sad, were fixed eagerly upon the wide white road stretching away in the distance until it was lost among the hills.

At length, with an impatient sigh, he turned his pale, wan face towards his mother and said:

"See, mother, the sun has nearly set; why tarryeth Leah so long? 'Twas but sunrise when she did set out for Samaria, surely she should have returned ere this."

"Thou dost forget, my son, that thy sister had much to do in Samaria," replied Sarah, soothingly. "First to dispose of the fruits and then to purchase necessities for our household; also the ass of our neighbor being old and stiff, can travel but slowly."

"All that thou urgeth be true, mother," exclaimed the lad, petulantly. "But my sister has ever the same tasks, still she always returned from Samaria before the setting of the sun. I fear that some ill hath befallen her," and his lip quivered with pain while his large, soft eyes dilated with fear.

"How now, lad! why dost thou frighten thy mother with thy sickly fancies?" cried Ezra, impatiently, as Sarah's cheek grew pale. "What ill could have befallen thy sister?"

"She may have fallen into the hands of the Syrians, whom thou knoweth do make raids into our country and carry off captives," answered the lad, tremulously. "Oh, if I were only as other lads these burdens should not fall

upon the weak shoulders of a maiden. 'Twould be I who would journey into Samaria with the fruits," and tears of bitter pain and humiliation filled his eyes.

Sarah leaned forward and gently smoothed back the dark, curling hair from his white brow.

"Speak not thus, my son," she murmured, with infinite tenderness. "Thy mother loveth thee but the more tenderly because of thy affliction, and well dost thou know how thy sister's heart yearneth over thee."

A faint smile touched the lad's pale lips.

"Ah, mother," he said, "it is wicked of me to repine at my affliction when thou and my sister, Leah, do love me so well. But, oh, mother, if I were but strong and whole," and, covering his face with his hands, he sobbed aloud.

"Look up, lad, and dry thy tears, for yonder cometh our Leah," cried Ezra.

With an exclamation of joy, Isaac obeyed, and, lifting himself eagerly upon his elbow, watched with joyous eyes, the slow approach of an ass upon which was seated a maiden.

Ezra went forward and lifted her to the ground.

"Leah! sister! thou art come at last!" cried Isaac.

She ran to the couch and bent over him; his weak arms clasped her neck, his eyes looked lovingly into her face.

The brother and sister had the same fine-cut features and beautiful, soft, dark eyes, but the lad's face was white and wan, while the rich bloom of health colored the cheeks and lips of the maiden. Her dark hair, curly and silken, fell to her waist; she was slenderly built, but erect, graceful and quick of movement.

"Why didst thou tarry so long, my child?" asked Sarah. "Thy brother has sorely fretted, fearing that some ill had befallen thee."

"I am sorry that thou didst fret, brother," said the maiden, bending to kiss his pale brow.

"Hadst thou trouble in disposing of the fruits, maiden?" asked Ezra.

"No, dear father," replied Leah, turning towards him with a smile. "I was but a little while selling the fruits and making the purchases for my mother."

"Then it was the slowness of our neighbor's ass which did delay thee," said Ezra.

"I will tell thee, father, why I did tarry so long in Samaria," said the maiden. "They were talking in Samaria of the wonders wrought by the prophet, Elisha, and I lingered to listen. 'Twas of his last miracle that they did speak. Father, mother, brother, knoweth thou that the prophet, Elisha, hath power to raise the dead to life?"

She paused and turned her eyes upon the helpless form of the cripple lad while the color deepened upon her cheek and her breath came quickly. Isaac spoke not, but, as his eyes met his sister's, they lighted with passionate eagerness and a long, panting sigh left his lips.

"What sayeth thou, maiden, that the prophet, Elisha, hath power to raise the dead to life?" cried Ezra, wonderingly and incredulously.

"Yes, father," answered Leah. "Listen, and I will tell to thee what I heard in Samaria. There is a woman in Shunem who didst bear to her husband in his old age a son. This woman, who is charitable and good, is well known to Elisha. Indeed she had prepared a chamber for him in her home where he did rest and take refreshment when he travelled on foot from place to place. One morning, when the woman's child was but five years of age, he went into the field where his father was gathering in the harvest, and, there, he suddenly sickened from the heat of the sun. They carried him to his mother, she held him in her arms and, after some hours, he died. She took him up to the little chamber where the prophet had rested and laid him upon the bed. Then, commanding the servant to saddle an ass, she set out to seek Elisha who was at Mount Carmel.

"Elisha, standing upon the summit, near the altar of Jehovah, saw her a-far off, for he sent his servant to inquire if all were well with her. But the

woman would herself speak with the prophet, and, falling at his feet, did tell him that her son was dead. Elisha then returned with the woman to Shunem and shut himself into the room with the dead child. After a little while he called his servant and told him to summon the mother, and, when she did come into the room, Elisha said to her, 'Take up thy child,' and the child was risen from the dead."

The little maid ceased speaking, and throwing herself on her knees beside the couch, put her arms gently about Isaac's frail form.

"Sister," murmured the lad, touching tenderly with his thin fingers the curling hair which fell upon her shoulders, "I know the thoughts in thy tender heart. Thou art thinking that if this great prophet hath power to raise the dead to life, then also hath he the power to make strong and straight these poor limbs of mine. Tell me, dear sister, are not these thy thoughts?"

"Yes! ah, indeed, yes!" cried the maiden, in a voice of passionate tenderness and yearning. "But I did not wish thee to know what was in my heart until I had spoken with our parents."

She arose and turned towards Ezra and Sarah. Both regarded her in silence; Ezra, pale and grave, Sarah, with tears in her eyes.

"Father, wilt thou give me leave to seek the prophet, Elisha, who dwelleth in Samaria that I may beg of him to heal my brother?" asked the maiden.

"Dost thou believe, maiden, that the wonderful things they relate of this Elisha be true?" asked Ezra.

Into the maiden's soft eyes there crept a troubled look.

"Oh, dear father speak not thus," she cried, imploringly. "Surely thou knoweth that unless we have faith, nothing will be granted unto us. Why shouldst thou or I doubt the wonders imputed to Elisha, for is he not a holy man of God?"

"Thou art only a maiden, but thou speaketh words of wisdom which do rebuke thy father," said Ezra. "Tell me, my son," turning to Isaac, "dost thou

also believe that this man, Elisha, hath power to heal thee, who art from thy birth a cripple?"

The lad looked, smiling, up into his father's face.

"Yes, father, I do indeed believe that Elisha hath power to heal me," he replied. "Even though he had not raised the dead to life still would my faith in him be great, for, as Leah sayeth, he be a holy man of God."

Ezra moved forward and laid his hand on the maiden's dark head.

"Thy brother also hath great faith," he said. "Thou shalt seek Elisha in Samaria and make known to him thy desire."

Leah caught her father's hand and raised it to her lips.

"I thank thee, my father," she murmured.

"Dost thou think that Elisha will harken to thy request?" asked Ezra.

"I am sure that he will, for Elisha never turneth a deaf ear to the sorrowful and the afflicted," answered Leah. "Father, when may I journey to Samaria and seek the prophet?"

"Nay, nay, have patience, maiden," said Ezra. "We will talk of that later, now 'tis time to prepare the evening meal. Assist thy mother, while I go forth and feed our neighbor's ass."

He turned away.

The sun had set, but a faint flush of crimson still lingered in the west. The ass stood patiently, with drooping head.

A light flashed out from the low doorway. Ezra, as he fed and watered the tired beast, could see his wife and daughter moving about within; also the form of the cripple lad stretched upon the couch. Would that wan cheek ever glow with health? mused Ezra. That weak body be upright and sturdy, those helpless limbs strong and straight?

"From his birth hath he been a cripple, sickly and helpless," murmured Ezra. "But surely this man who hath power even to raise the dead to life can heal a cripple lad."

"Father! father!"

Leah stood in the doorway, her cheeks the color of roses, the night breeze lifting her heavy curls, her soft eyes gazing forth into the gathering shadows.

"Come, dear father, the evening meal is ready," she said.

The day's tasks were done. Isaac, exhausted with the emotions and excitement of the day, slept heavily upon his couch. Ezra and Sarah sat in the doorway and the little maid lay upon the ground at their feet, with her curly head resting against her mother's knee.

"Art thou fatigued with thy journey, maiden?" asked Sarah, touching caressingly Leah's rose-flushed cheek.

"Fatigued!" repeated the maiden, with a smile. "No, dear mother, thy Leah is young and strong; 'tis only the poor old ass that is weary."

Ezra sat buried in thought. Now and again the little maid glanced wistfully up into his face. She longed passionately to learn when it was his will for her to seek the prophet in Samaria, but it never occurred to her to question her father or manifest any signs of impatience.

A silence fell upon the three. Sarah thought that the little maid had fallen asleep, so still she lay, but, as Ezra suddenly roused himself and spoke, Leah, sat upright, her eyes eagerly seeking his face across which the light from within fell.

"Maiden," said Ezra, "I have been considering the matter of thy seeking the prophet, Elisha, in Samaria. When ten days have passed the fruits will again have ripened; then will I borrow the ass of our neighbor and thou shalt journey to Samaria. When thou hast sold thy fruits thou canst seek the prophet, Elisha."

Leah's eyes filled with tears, her lips quivered, she was bitterly disappointed. To wait ten days when she hoped and longed to start with the coming dawn for Samaria.

"Thou didst hear me, maiden?" said Ezra, as she did not speak.

"Yes, my father," she replied, as she wiped away her tears. "'Tis thy will that I again journey to Samaria when ten days shall have passed."

"Such is my will," said Ezra.

The little maid laid her head again upon her mother's lap and looked, with longing, wistful eyes, into the darkness towards Samaria.

CHAPTER II.

"Sister, how many days have passed since thou didst return from Samaria?" asked Isaac, as Leah, her morning's work completed, seated herself beside his couch.

"Five, brother," replied the little maid. "So but five more remain and then I shall again journey to Samaria."

The lad sighed deeply.

"Every day that dawns is long and dreary to me," he said; "but these last five days have seemed indeed the longest and dreariest of all my life. Leah, sometimes during the long, pain-racked hours of the night, my heart hath risen in bitterness against my father that he so long delayeth thy journey to Samaria."

"Nay, dear brother, speak not thus," said the little maid, gently. "Our father knoweth best."

"But, Leah," cried the lad, his eyes lighting eagerly, a faint flush staining the pallor of his cheek, "if our father had permitted thee to journey at once to Samaria, perhaps, when the fruits were ripe it would have been I who didst carry them to Samaria."

"Be patient a little longer, dear brother," said Leah. "And promise me that thou wilt not again cherish bitter thoughts against our father," she added, earnestly.

"I promise thee, sister," answered the lad. "Poor father, 'tis a heavy burden upon him that his eldest-born and only son should be a cripple; that while he toileth I lie here helpless, unable to give him a helping hand, to lighten his labor. But, oh, Leah, sister, how happy I shall be when the prophet, Elisha, hath made me whole. How proudly shall I labor by my father's side; and thou shalt journey no more to Samaria; thou shalt stay at our mother's side while I carry the fruits to the city and purchase necessities

for our household. Sister! Sister! what did the woman of Shunem when Elisha raised her child from the dead?"

"She fell in gratitude at the feet of Elisha," answered the little maid.

"I shall also fall in gratitude at the feet of Elisha when he hath made me whole," said Isaac.

"Thou must not forget to offer up prayers of gratitude to the great Jehovah from whom cometh the power of Elisha," said Leah, gently.

Ezra was at work in the fields when he saw his wife, Sarah, approaching.

"What seeketh thou, Sarah?" he asked, as she drew near.

"I would speak with thee, Ezra," replied Sarah.

"Of what wouldst thou speak, Sarah, that thou seeketh me in the fields at my labor?" asked Ezra. "Canst thou not wait until the day's toil be ended?"

"Nay, or I would not seek thee at thy labor," answered Sarah. "I would not speak with thee of this before our children lest they think that thy wife hold but lightly her husband's judgment. Ezra, the hearts of our children are sad that thou delayeth the maiden's journey to Samaria."

"Our children be young and knoweth not patience," said Ezra.

"Nay, Ezra, our son and eldest-born hath never known youth," sadly answered Sarah. "Youth is sturdy of body, light of limb, joyous of heart. Isaac knoweth naught of these things. Impatient, sayeth thou, Ezra? Ay, and thou also would be impatient, even with the years of wisdom upon thy shoulders, if thou wert crippled from birth, and when the light of hope shone, for the first time, across thy dark pathway, thou wert bidden to wait."

"'Tis but a few days until the fruits shall have ripened," muttered Ezra.

"Ay, thou art right," said Sarah, "'tis but a few days, but a little while ago I did hear our son say that the five days of waiting had been the longest and dreariest of a life in which every day is long and dreary."

"Thou art but a woman, Sarah, and the softness of thy heart doth steal away thy wisdom," said Ezra.

"'Tis not so much the woman's heart as the mother's that doth plead with thee, Ezra," replied Sarah, the tears filling her eyes.

"Go back to thy children and thy work, woman," commanded Ezra. "And when the day's toil be ended we will speak of this again."

Sarah turned obediently away, but her heart was light, for her husband had not said her nay.

"Come hither, maiden," said Ezra.

The evening meal was over and the night shadows were falling. Leah arose from beside her father's couch and approached Ezra.

"Little maid," said Ezra, "maketh thyself ready, for to-morrow, at the dawning of the day, our neighbor will bring his ass and thou shalt set forth for Samaria."

The maiden's lips parted eagerly with surprise and joy. The lad, lifted himself upon his elbow, and gazed upon his father with radiant eyes.

"But, father, the fruits are not yet ripe," faltered Leah.

"That is true," replied Ezra. "But we shall not wait until the fruits have ripened. Art thou not eager, maiden, to seek the prophet, Elisha, in Samaria that thou mayest beg of him to heal thy brother?"

"Yes, yes, dear father," cried the little maid, with shining eyes and flushing cheeks.

"Then make ready to start upon thy journey at the dawn of day," said Ezra.

"I shall be ready, dear father," replied Leah.

She turned and went back to her brother's couch. She knelt down beside him and slipped her hand in his. He lifted the little hand to his lips and kissed it reverently and tenderly.

When in the gray dawn of the early morning Leah entered Isaac's chamber she found him sleeping. She pressed a kiss upon his brow and stole softly out again.

"Thou didst find thy brother sleeping," said Sarah. "He passed a night of pain and restlessness and now sleepeth from exhaustion. But it will fret him not to have bidden thee farewell."

"'Tis well that he is resting after his night of pain," said Leah. "Tell him, dear mother, that I kissed him as he slept."

"Come, maiden," called Ezra from without.

"Fare-thee-well, dear mother," murmured the little maid.

Sarah kissed tenderly the sweet, upturned face.

"Fare-thee-well, my child," she said, tremulously. "God be with thee."

Then the little maid passed through the doorway and out into the grayness of the breaking day. Ezra lifted her upon the ass's back and she turned her face towards Samaria.

When Isaac awoke he called his mother to him and said:

"Mother, has my sister started for Samaria?"

"Yes, my son," replied Sarah.

His lips quivered.

"Why didst thou not awaken me, mother, that I might bid my sister farewell?" he said.

"Thou wert resting, my son, after thy night of pain," answered Sarah. "Thy sister would not have thee awakened, but bid me say to thee that she kissed thee as thou slept. See," pointing to a golden gleam of sunlight which forced itself through the window and lay athwart the bed, "'tis the first ray of the rising sun; ere it sets thy sister will be again with thee."

And the lad lay gazing, with a smile upon his lips, at the shaft of golden light.

Ezra labored all day in the fields. The sun was sinking low in the heavens when he saw approaching the neighbor whose ass he had borrowed.

"Good-evening, neighbor," said Ezra. "Thou art come too soon for thy ass; the maiden hath not yet returned."

"I come not for the ass, neighbor," replied the man, whose name was Simeon. "I bring thee ill tidings."

"What meaneth thou, neighbor?" asked Ezra.

"Ill hath befallen thy little maid," was the reply.

"Ill hath befallen my little maid," repeated Ezra, bewilderedly. "Speak, man, what ill?"

"She has been taken captive by the Syrians," answered Simeon.

"How knoweth thou this?" asked Ezra.

"I will tell thee," said his neighbor. "But a little while ago a stranger did come to my house mounted upon my own ass. 'Be this beast thine?' he did ask me. Much astonished I replied that the ass were mine. 'And the maiden who rode it, was she thy daughter?' asked the stranger. I replied that she was not my daughter, but the little maid of my neighbor, Ezra. Then the stranger said to me, 'Go to thy neighbor Ezra and tell him that his little maid hath been taken captive by the Syrians; that she will be carried to Damascus and sold into slavery.'

"It doth appear," continued Simeon, as Ezra stood pale and speechless, "that this man was traveling on foot from Samaria when he saw approaching from the direction of Damascus, a company of Syrians. They were evidently bent upon plunder, and the man, fearing that they would take him captive, did hide himself. While in hiding he saw the Syrians fall in with a little maid mounted upon an ass. The maiden they did take captive, leaving the ass which is old and slow. When the Syrians had departed with the little maid, the stranger came forth and mounted the ass, turning its face in the direction from whence it came. And the ass returned home. It is with sorrow in my heart, neighbor, that I bring thee ill tidings of thy little maid."

"Ay, ill tidings indeed!" murmured Ezra, his head sunk in sorrow upon his breast. "The hand of the Lord hath fallen heavily upon me and mine. How shall I tell the lad, for whose sake she did journey towards Samaria, of the ill that hath befallen his sister? Alas! alas! our little maid captured by the Syrians! sold into slavery!" and Ezra rent his garments and wept bitterly.

CHAPTER III.

Naaman, commander-in-chief of the Syrian Army, was passing through the streets of Damascus in a magnificent chariot drawn by four snow-white horses. He was a man of great height and superb physique; he wore a robe of royal purple. But upon the proud face there rested a heavy shadow, and the dark, flashing eyes, which had looked death in the face unflinchingly so many times upon the battle-field, now drooped under the pitying and curious glances bent upon him.

A sigh of intense relief heaved his mighty chest when the chariot stopped before the gates of a stately palace. He stepped from the chariot and passed within.

"Say to thy mistress that I desire her presence," he said to a servant, and then passed on to a splendid chamber.

With his arms clasped across his breast he paced restlessly up and down the vast length of the chamber.

"Ah," he murmured, "Naaman, whom all Syria doth call a mighty man of valor, knoweth fear for the first time. My hand doth tremble like a woman's, my limbs are weak. Never have her sweet eyes looked into mine save with tenderness, but now—alas! alas! that Naaman should be so accursed."

The heavy silken draperies of the doorway were put aside and a woman entered the chamber. She was very beautiful with skin of dazzling fairness and hair of wondrous gold color. She was clad in rich garments of white, embroidered with gold.

"Naaman, my husband," she murmured, tenderly.

At the sound of her sweet voice Naaman started, turned, moved towards her and then abruptly paused.

"Thou didst desire my presence, my lord," she continued, falteringly, for his face was white and stern, and she remembered how of late he had appeared so cold and changed. As he did not speak, she added, "I fear that some trouble doth sore oppress thee. For some time I have noted the pallor on thy cheek, the shadow on thy brow. I longed to know thy trouble that I might comfort thee, but thou art ever silent. Wilt thou not confide in me, Naaman? Surely thou knoweth that thy Claudia desireth not alone to share thy riches and thy honors, but thy sorrows also," and, moving to his side, she laid her beautiful white hand upon his arm.

He started back, thrusting her almost roughly aside.

"Touch me not, woman!" he cried; "for I am—unclean."

She stared at him, her eyes dark with horror, the delicate bloom fading from cheeks and lips. He shuddered and covered his face with his hands.

"Naaman, what meaneth thou?" she asked. "My husband, speak."

His hands fell, he turned and faced her.

"Claudia," he said, "this morning, as I passed through the streets of Damascus, glances of pity and loathing were cast upon me, until, I, Naaman, did bow my head in shame. I have riches, fame and honor, but the very beggars in the streets do pity me for I am a—leper."

She shrank back with a faint cry.

"Ay, 'tis true," he continued, bitterly. "All Damascus doth know what I have feared to tell to thee because I love thee; because I did fear to read in thy sweet eyes the horror and the loathing with which all regard me. The leper is accursed, unclean, whom many loathe, all pity, but none may love."

"Nay, thou art wrong," murmured Claudia, tenderly. "Thy wife doth love thee, ay, but the more tenderly because of thy affliction."

Into Naaman's haggard eyes there flashed a look of joy.

"Then Naaman careth not for the pitying and loathing of all Syria since Claudia still loveth him," he cried.

Claudia, wife of Naaman, was wandering listlessly through the beautiful grounds which surrounded the palace. Her lovely face was pale, her eyes full of sadness. She rarely went beyond the grounds of the palace, shrinking from the compassionate glances bent upon her, and the murmurs which too often reached her ears:

"See! 'tis Claudia, the wife of Naaman, the leper."

Suddenly through the gates of the palace there came a little maid. She was poorly-clad, but, as she drew near, her sweet face attracted the attention of Claudia.

"Who art thou, little one?" she asked.

"I am Leah, a slave," replied the little maid, while her dark head drooped in shame.

"A slave!" repeated Claudia. "Cometh thou not from the land of Israel?" she asked.

"Yes," replied Leah. "I was captured by a company of Syrians while on my way to Samaria, brought to Damascus and placed in the slave market where I was bought by Eucadeus, a wine-merchant. 'Tis he who hath sent me to the palace of Naaman where he selleth his wine."

"Captured and sold into slavery—'tis a hard fate for one so young," murmured Claudia, musingly. "Knoweth thou who I am, maiden?"

"I know not who thou art," replied the little maid, with a smile. "But I see that thou art very beautiful, and my heart doth tell me that thou art good. Thou art also a great lady, for thou weareth rich garments and rare jewels."

Claudia smiled.

"Thy answer doth please me, little maid; thou hath an apt tongue," she said. "I am Claudia, wife of Naaman."

The soft, dark eyes of the little maid were lifted to Claudia's face with a swift look of compassion. For a moment Claudia shrank back and was

silent.

"Ah," she thought, "even this slave-girl knoweth that Naaman is a leper and doth pity Naaman's wife. Wouldst thou like to enter my service, maiden?" she asked. "If so, no doubt, thou canst be bought of thy master, Eucadeus."

Leah's eyes lighted with rapture.

"Ay, lady, glad indeed would I be to enter thy service," she replied. "I am sure thou couldst buy me of Eucadeus, for he loveth gold above all things."

"Then I shall send my chief steward to Eucadeus," said Claudia. "Now, hasten, maiden, to do thy errand, lest thy master chide thee for tarrying."

Claudia returned to the palace and, summoning her chief steward, said to him:

"Seek thou the wine-merchant, Eucadeus, and say to him that Claudia, wife of Naaman, would purchase of him Leah, the little Israelite maid, upon whom he may set his own price."

The chief steward accordingly went to do his mistress' bidding.

Eucadeus, a hard, cruel, grasping fellow, who put upon the little maid tasks far beyond her strength, was at first unwilling to part with his slave. But, upon learning that it was Claudia, wife of Naaman, who desired to purchase her, and that he might name his own price, he quickly changed his mind and bargained with the chief steward for a price just double that which he had paid for the maiden.

The chief steward, though much disgusted with the old man's avarice and extortion, handed over the pieces of gold which he named as his price for the maiden and returned to the palace bringing Leah with him.

Claudia appointed Leah her own hand-maiden and soon became very much attached to her; Leah, in return, devotedly loved her beautiful kind mistress.

One day, after she had been some months in the household of Naaman, Leah, who had been watching wistfully her mistress' beautiful, sad face,

said:

"Ah, my dear mistress, how pale and sorrowful thou looketh. My heart acheth for thee; would that I could help thee."

Claudia smiled with infinite sadness and laid her hand affectionately upon the dark, curly head of her hand-maiden.

"Thou hast a tender heart, little one," she said. "I am sure thou wouldst help me if thou couldst. But no one can do that, not even the wisest and greatest in all Syria."

"But there be one in Israel who can help thee," said the little maid.

"What meaneth thou, child?" asked Claudia. "Dost thou know what doth render me so sorrowful?"

"Yes, dear mistress," replied the little maid, "'tis because Naaman, thy husband, whom thou dost dearly love, art a leper."

"Ay, most true," murmured Claudia, with a deep sigh. "Therefore, maiden, why sayeth thou that there be one in the land of Israel who can help me? Surely thou dost know that no one can heal the leper."

"Listen, dear mistress," said Leah. "The prophet, Elisha, who is in Samaria, can heal my lord, thy husband, for he hath done most wonderful things even to the raising of the dead to life."

Claudia listened with breathless eagerness and attention.

"Thou art but a maiden and a slave," she said, "but I shall give heed to thy words and repeat them to Naaman, my husband. Go tell thy master that I would speak with him."

When Naaman entered his wife's presence she turned to meet him with a look in her beautiful eyes that he had not seen there in many months.

"Thy little hand-maiden didst tell me that thou desireth my presence," he said.

"Yes," replied Claudia. "Oh, Naaman, my husband! this little maid of Israel hath told me most wonderful things. She claimeth that in Samaria

there is a prophet called Elisha who hath power to heal thee of thy leprosy. Oh, my husband, thou must at once seek this man."

"I must first seek counsel of the king," said Naaman.

"Then go at once and tell to the king what the maiden sayeth," cried Claudia, and Naaman went from her presence to seek that of Benhadad, king of Syria.



CHAPTER IV.

"What is thy will with me, good Naaman?" asked Benhadad, king of Syria, with whom the Syrian general stood high in favor.

"I am come to seek counsel of thee, my lord," replied Naaman. "My wife hath a maid-servant who cometh from the land of Israel, and this maiden sayeth that in Samaria there is a prophet called Elisha, who hath done most marvelous things even to the raising of the dead to life. The maiden claimeth that if I seek the prophet, Elisha, he will heal me of my leprosy. What thinketh thou, my lord? dost thou believe that which the maiden sayeth be true?"

"I have never heard of this Elisha," replied Benhadad. "He is no doubt a magician, and, if what the maiden sayeth be true, his power far exceedeth that of any magician at my court. Thou shalt journey to Samaria, my Naaman, bearing a letter from me to Jehoram, king of Israel. This Elisha is perhaps attached to the court of Jehoram, but, if not, the king hath power to make his subjects do his bidding. Take with thee gold in plenty to reward this Elisha."

Naaman kissed the hand of the king and went forth from his presence. Upon the day following his interview with Benhadad, Naaman, in great pomp and splendor, set forth upon his journey to Samaria. He carried with him ten talents of silver, six thousand pieces of gold (about sixty thousand dollars) and ten changes of costly raiment with which to reward Elisha.

The first blush of the rising sun lay upon the city of Damascus as the magnificent caravan of Naaman passed through its gates. Naaman and his retinue journeyed over the uplands of Bashan, through the valley of Jordan, and upon the fifth day stood before the gates of Samaria.

Then Naaman, ordering the caravan to halt, called one of his servants to him and said:

"Send ahead a messenger to Jehoram, king of Israel, announcing that Naaman, the great Syrian general, art approaching with his retinue and desireth audience with him."

A fair-haired lad, robed in scarlet and mounted upon a jet-black horse of wonderful swiftness, bore Naaman's message to the king. So when the caravan reached the palace, Jehoram was waiting to receive Naaman.

Tall and lithe of form, straight of feature was the Israelite king. The long hair, bound by the jeweled crown, was black as the raven's wing. There was a flush upon his dark brow and a troubled look in his eyes as Naaman entered his presence.

"Thou art Naaman, general in the Syrian Army," he said, "and thou seeketh speech with me?"

"Yes, I am Naaman," replied the Syrian, as he bent his proud head before Israel's dark king. "I have journeyed from Damascus, bearing this letter from Benhadad, king of all Syria to Jehoram, king of Israel," and taking the parchment from his breast, he presented it to Jehoram.

The latter read the letter and his face turned white. Lifting his eyes, angry and disturbed, he fixed them upon Naaman.

"Thou art a leper?" he said, while a look of loathing passed over his face.

A dark red flush of shame and humiliation rose to Naaman's proud brow. "Yes, my lord, I am a leper," he replied.

The king fell into deep thought, his brows drawn together in a frown.

Naaman, standing at the foot of the throne in torturing suspense, noted that the king was greatly disturbed. His thin lips were unsteady, the long, slim fingers, which held the golden sceptre, trembled.

At length, the king roused himself, and, turning his eyes again upon Naaman, he asked:

"Knoweth thou the contents of this letter?"

"Yes, my lord," replied Naaman.

"I must have time to consider this request of Benhadad," continued the king. Naaman's face paled. He had not anticipated any hesitation on the part of Jehoram to grant the wish of Benhadad, knowing how unwise it would be for political reasons for Jehoram thus to act. If the king of Israel noted Naaman's disturbance he gave no sign of it.

"Seek me to-morrow at this time," he said, "and thou shalt have my answer to the letter of thy king."

As soon as Naaman had departed Jehoram summoned the counselors and wise men of his kingdom and thus addressed them:

"Benhadad, king of Syria, seeketh a quarrel with me. He maketh a request which he knoweth it be impossible for me to grant. I fear that he doth this for the purpose of provoking war as his father, Benhadad I, before him, did with my father, Ahab."

"My lord, what meaneth thou?" anxiously inquired one of the wise men of the kingdom.

"The king hath sent to me Naaman, the great Syrian general, with a letter which I will read to thee," replied the king. "'Now when this letter is come unto thee, behold I send herewith Naaman, my servant, that thou mayest cure him of his leprosy.' Seeth thou how he seeketh a quarrel with me?" cried the king, as he rent his garments. "Am I God to kill and give life that Benhadad sendeth to me a man to be cured of his leprosy?"

The wise men and the counselors of the kingdom looked silently and apprehensively into one another's faces, for they knew not what to say to the king.

"It doth appear that Benhadad mocks me," said the king, "for well he knoweth that no man hath the power to heal the leper."

"My lord, what answer hast thou given to Naaman who brought to thee the king's letter?" asked one of the wise men.

"I have given him as yet no answer," replied Jehoram. "I did send him away, bidding him return to-morrow. In the meanwhile, I have summoned thee, my counselors and wise men, that we may confer together."

"Thinketh thou, my lord, that this Naaman, who cometh in such pomp and splendor to Samaria, be in truth a leper?" asked one of the counselors.

"Truly I know not," answered the king. "But when I didst ask him if he were a leper, his face flushed with shame and he replied, 'Yes, I am a leper.' He is a man of magnificent form and stately bearing, he is evidently of great wealth and high in favor with Benhadad, Syria's king. He is also a soldier and a man of valor. But why waste we time in discussing this Syrian. Let us rather take counsel as to what answer we shall send to his king."

"My lord, what answer canst thou send to Benhadad, king of Syria, save that thou art not God and, therefore, hath not the power to heal the leper?" asked one of the wise men.

The king frowned.

"Thus would I do as Benhadad wisheth—give him pretext to make war upon me," he cried, impatiently. "Thou speaketh with scant wisdom, Mahab. Benhadad knoweth well that it be not in the power of man to heal the leper. But I would temporize with him, not thus openly give him pretext to make war upon Israel."

At that moment one of the king's servants entered and said:

"My lord, a servant of the prophet, Elisha, is without and desireth speech with thee."

"He must seek me later," cried the king, impatiently. "I am engaged at present with the counselors and wise men of my kingdom upon a matter of grave import."

"Pardon thy servant, my lord," persisted the servant, "but this man bid me say that his master hath sent him to speak words of counsel that neither the wise men nor the counselors of thy kingdom could give unto thee."

The king started.

"Ah!" he exclaimed, "now I do remember that this Elisha be a great prophet and a holy man of God. Go, bring hither his servant."

The servant withdrew, returning in few moments with a man simply clad and grave of mien.

"My lord," he said to Jehoram, "my master, Elisha, the prophet, bade me seek thee and say, 'Why hast thou rent thy garments? Sendeth to me this Naaman of Syria that he may know there is a prophet in Israel.'"

CHAPTER V.

At the appointed time, upon the day following, Naaman again presented himself before Jehoram, king of Israel.

The latter had assembled about him his courtiers, counselors and wise men. He appeared no longer troubled nor disturbed. He looked with serene eyes upon Naaman, into which, however, there flashed a look of loathing as he remembered that the man before him was a leper.

The courtiers, counselors and wise men of the Kingdom also looked with aversion upon Naaman, notwithstanding the nobility of his form, his handsome, proud face and the magnificence of his raiment, for in Israel the leper is an object of intense aversion, and, had Naaman been an Israelite, he would have been banished in spite of his rank, wealth and the services he had rendered to his country.

The king of Israel and those of his court were deeply incensed that Benhadad, king of Syria, had sent into their midst, to the person of the king himself, a man afflicted with leprosy.

Naaman stood, with folded arms and grave face, waiting for the king to speak.

For some moments Jehoram was silent, pondering the wisest and most judicious manner of making known to Naaman his wish regarding him. The king was perfectly sure that Elisha would extricate him from his difficulty, for had not the prophet bade his servant say, 'Why hast thou rent thy garments?' which meant literally, 'Why art thou troubled and of so little faith?'

But the king, laboring under an erroneous idea as to Benhadad's motive in sending Naaman to him, wished so to act as to leave Benhadad no pretext for making war upon him. Benhadad had in reality desired to be complimentary in the wording of his letter in order to propitiate Jehoram, so that the latter would command Elisha to heal Naaman.

"Naaman of Syria," said Jehoram, "I did promise thee an answer to the letter of thy king. Go thou to the house in Samaria of the prophet, Elisha, and say unto him, 'I am Naaman of Syria, a leper, who hast come to thee to be made whole.' Then will Elisha heal thee of thy leprosy."

"My lord, I know not where dwelleth this Elisha," said Naaman.

"I will send a servant to guide thee," said the king.

So Naaman entered his chariot, and with all his retinue, started for the home of the prophet. The king's servant led the way on foot. The magnificent caravan passed through the streets of Samaria, wound among the hills and stopped before a small and lowly dwelling.

Lifting himself from among his silken cushions, Naaman called impatiently to one of his servants,

"Why hast the caravan come thus to a halt?"

"At the command of the king's servant, my lord," was the reply.

"Send to me the king's servant," cried Naaman, angrily.

In a few moments the servant of the king stood beside the chariot.

"Why hast thou thus stopped the caravan of Naaman?" asked the Syrian nobleman, angrily.

"My lord, I am but fulfilling the orders of the king, my master," was the reply.

"Thou speaketh falsely," cried Naaman, with increasing anger. "Thy master didst command thee to conduct me to the house of Elisha, the prophet."

"My lord, I have obeyed the order of my master," said the servant. "This is the house of Elisha, the prophet."

"'Tis impossible!" cried Naaman, incredulously. "A great man like Elisha must surely dwell in a palace. This is the abode of a man, humble, obscure; Elisha is rich and famous."

The king's servant regarded Naaman wonderingly.

"Pardon me, my lord, but thou dost know little regarding the prophet Elisha," he said. "'Tis true that his fame hath gone forth over the land, but Elisha hath not riches; he is a man, poor and humble; he dwelleth not in a palace, this is his home."

Naaman, perplexed and wondering, waved the servant of the king impatiently aside and summoning one of his own servants, said to him:

"Go thou into the house of Elisha and say to him that Naaman, general in the Syrian Army, high in favor with Benhadad, king of Syria, doth desire speech with him."

The servant passed into the house of Elisha. In a short while he came forth alone.

"Is not the prophet, Elisha, within?" asked Naaman, impatiently.

"Yes, my lord," was the answer, "but I saw him not. The servant of Elisha did carry the message to his master."

"And what answer sendeth Elisha?" asked Naaman, with eagerness.

"Elisha desireth to know, my lord, what is thy will with him," replied the servant.

Naaman's brow darkened with displeasure.

"Is it thus that the great and rich Naaman of Syria is received by the poor and humble Elisha?" he cried. Then, remembering the errand upon which he had come, he controlled his indignation, thinking, "I must humor this man if I would have my will of him: Go thou again into the house of Elisha," he said, "and bid the servant say to his master, that Naaman of Syria hath journeyed from Damascus that Elisha may heal him of his leprosy."

The servant turned away and passed into the house. In a few minutes he returned with the servant of Elisha who, approaching Naaman, said:

"My master, Elisha sayeth unto Naaman of Syria, 'Go thou and bathe seven times in the Jordan and thy flesh shalt recover health and thou shalt

be clean."

"Dost thy master mean to mock me that he treateth me as though I were but a common outcast leper?" cried Naaman. "I did think that he would have come out to see me, and, touching with his hand the place of the leprosy, would have invoked the name of Jehovah, his God, and healed me. Go wash seven times in the Jordan? What marvelous power doth the Jordan possess? But enough of this folly. Thy master doth but speak in jest. Go say to him that Naaman of Syria came not to be mocked, but to be cured of his leprosy, and that he bringeth with him a great treasure with which to reward Elisha."

"My lord, it would avail naught for me to carry thy message to my master," said the servant. "Elisha hath spoken," and, turning, he passed quietly among the servants of Naaman and entered the lowly dwelling of his master.

Naaman sat for some moments in silence. The servant of the king looked up at him eagerly and seemed about to speak, but awed, perhaps, by the Syrian's white face and sombre eyes, remained silent.

At length, Naaman roused himself, sprang to his feet, and drawing his splendid form to its full height, cried in a loud voice:

"Back to Damascus! Naaman hath but come upon a fool's errand." Then turning upon the servant of the king, he cried, in tones of great anger, "Go to thy master, Jehoram, king of Israel, and say to him that Benhadad, king of all Syria, will know how to avenge the insult that hath been offered to Naaman."

"But, my lord, the king, my master, didst intend thee no insult," protested the servant. "The ways of Elisha are not like unto the ways of other men."

"Stop not to parley with me!" cried Naaman, furiously. "Be gone ere I bid my servants drive thee hence."

The servant of the king bowed his head and passed swiftly away.

"Now, onward to Damascus," said Naaman, throwing himself wearily back upon the cushions.

At that moment, however, one of Naaman's servants, a white-haired old man, approached the chariot and said:

"Wilt my lord hear patiently old Masrekah whose hair has grown gray in his service and who didst serve his father before him?"

"Speak, my good Masrekah," answered Naaman.

"My lord, thou art a mighty man of valor and know not the meaning of fear," continued Masrekah. "If the prophet, Elisha, bade thee do some act difficult of achievement, thou wouldst have listened and obeyed?"

"Ay, most willingly," replied Naaman.

"Then, my master, do not despise this thing that Elisha bid thee do because it is a simple thing," said Masrekah. "My lord, I do not believe that Elisha doth intend thee mockery and insult. Didst thou not take heed of the words of the king's servant, 'The ways of Elisha are not like unto the ways of other men?' Thou, my lord, didst expect to find him in a palace, but instead he dwelleth as do the poor and lowly. Thou didst think that he would heal thee with ostentatious and impressive ceremonial, but he sendeth thee word to go to bathe seven times in the Jordan and thou shalt be clean. My Lord, despise not the bidding of Elisha."

"Thou speaketh with the wisdom of years, my good Masrekah," answered Naaman. "Naaman will give heed to thy words. I go to bathe seven times in the Jordan."

CHAPTER VI.

Upon leaving the caravan of Naaman, the servant of the king returned to the palace and sought his master.

"What tidings dost thou bring?" asked Jehoram. "Hath Elisha healed Naaman of his leprosy?"

"No, my lord," replied the servant, "and I bring to thee a message from Naaman who is greatly incensed," and he repeated to the king Naaman's message.

Jehoram's face grew pale.

The servant then proceeded to relate how Elisha had received Naaman and what he had bid him do.

"What meaneth Elisha?" cried Jehoram, in fear and anger. "Does he not know that he will bring destruction upon Israel?"

"I did say unto Naaman of Syria that the ways of Elisha, the prophet, were not like unto the ways of other men," said the servant. "But Naaman would not give heed to my words, he angrily bade me be gone."

"Go, mount the fleetest horse in my possession and make haste to the house of Elisha," commanded the king. "Say to him that if Naaman of Syria returneth in anger to Damascus, Benhadad, king of all Syria, will at once declare war upon Israel. Say to Elisha that Jehoram his king, doth command him to heal Naaman of his leprosy lest destruction come upon Israel."

"But, my lord, pardon thy servant for reminding thee that Naaman of Syria refused to do the bidding of Elisha," said the servant. "He believeth that Elisha does but mock him."

"Ah, this worshipper of a false god understandeth not the ways of a prophet of the true God of Israel," cried the king, scornfully. "But be that as it may Naaman must not return unhealed and in anger to Damascus. So go

thou with all speed and deliver my message to Elisha. The caravan of Naaman cannot have proceeded far; thou canst still overtake it after thou hast seen Elisha. Lose not a moment; go!"

After the departure of his servant Jehoram shut himself up alone in his chamber. He sought not the counsel of the wise men of his kingdom; he knew that no one could extricate him from threatened disaster save Elisha.

Impatiently the king tossed aside the jeweled crown which rested so heavily upon his aching brows.

"Ah, can all the glory of a king compensate for the cares that lie so heavily upon him? Jehoram, king of all Israel, often envyeth the humblest of his subjects."

Time passed and the king, restless with suspense, consumed with anxiety, awaited the coming of his servant. At length, the servant returned.

"Speak; what tidings dost thou bring?" cried the king.

"My lord," replied the servant, "I did hasten, as thou commanded, to the house of Elisha. His servant admitted me to the presence of the prophet and I delivered to him thy message. Elisha heard me in silence, then he spoke. 'Jehoram, king of Israel, hath but little faith,' he said. 'Go to thy master and say unto him that Naaman will return to Damascus healed of his leprosy.'"

A long sigh of relief broke from the lips of the king.

"Elisha be a prophet and a holy man of God," he said, "therefore, will I believe his words and have faith in him."

CHAPTER VII.

An hour before sunset, upon the day following his departure from Damascus, the caravan of Naaman reached the banks of the Jordan. The Jordan was very different from the beautiful Syrian rivers, Abaha and Pharpar. Its waters, muddy and discolored, flowed sluggishly between unshaded banks covered with coarse grass and rank weeds.

Naaman descended from his chariot and advanced to the banks of the river. He stood, for some moments, frowningly regarding the discolored water as it crept to his feet, then he threw aside his purple robe, disclosing upon his broad chest awful, loathsome sores. He stepped into the water.

In a few minutes he stood again upon the bank. His great muscular arms were crossed upon his breast, a gray pallor lay upon his face.

"I have done the bidding of Elisha," he cried, "I have bathed seven times in the Jordan, but my brain doth whirl, my eyes are dim and blurred. Masrekah, faithful servant, 'tis for thee to speak—am I whole or am I still a leper?" and he threw his arms wide apart.

In silent wonder and awe the servants of Naaman gazed upon their master. The loathsome, leprous spots had entirely disappeared, his flesh "was like unto the flesh of a little child."

But Naaman knew not that he was healed. His eyes, dim and dazed, were fixed upon the old servant. One downward glance would have told him all, but Naaman, soldier and mighty man of valor, now knew a coward's fear.

Masrekah came forward, and falling at his master's feet, covered his hands with kisses and tears of joy.

"Master! dearest master!" he cried, "thou art healed! thou art clean! thou art no more a leper."

A great tremor shook Naaman's massive limbs. He grew weak as a little child, his lips quivered and tears filled his eyes. His servants broke into

shouts of joy and exultation. They threw themselves on their knees before Naaman, kissing his hands and feet.

"Arise, my good and faithful servants," said Naaman. "Turn we our faces again towards Samaria. I go to seek the prophet, Elisha."

Masrekah laid his hand upon Naaman's arm.

"My lord," he said, "thou hast forgotten to render thanks to Rimmon, god of Syria, for the great good that hath been done unto thee. Masrekah thus presumeth to remind his lord lest the god, being angered, should send some calamity upon Naaman."

Naaman smiled.

"Naaman shall not render thanks to Rimmon, god of Syria," he said. "Nor doth Naaman fear the anger of Syria's god. Nay, be not troubled, my good Masrekah, all will be well with Naaman."

Naaman then arrayed himself in his purple robe and passed on to his chariot. For a moment he stood gazing upon the waters of the Jordan to which the crimson glow from the setting sun lent fleeting beauty. His eyes were filled with a great joy, an immeasurable peace. Then he stepped into his chariot and motioned for the caravan to proceed.

It was the same hour, upon the next day, that the caravan of Naaman again stood before the humble dwelling of Elisha. Naaman, calling one of his servants to him, said:

"Go thou into the house of Elisha and say to him, 'Naaman of Syria, having done thy bidding, bathed seven times in the Jordan, has come forth whole. He most earnestly desireth speech with thee, that he may tell to thee how his heart has changed, also give unto thee the ten talents of silver, six thousand pieces of gold and ten changes of raiment which he brought with him from Damascus.'"

The servant passed into the house of the prophet. In a short time he returned, saying:

"Elisha will come forth, my lord, and speak with thee."

Naaman alighted from the chariot and awaited the coming of the prophet. After a little while a man stepped through the low doorway of the humble dwelling and approached Naaman.

Tall and spare in figure, he wore a dark, coarse, robe, over which flowed a long, gray beard. His face was pale and worn, his eyes gentle and calm.

Naaman sank upon his knees at the feet of the prophet.

"Arise, Naaman of Syria," said Elisha, in a voice of wonderful sweetness.

Naaman pressed the coarse robe of the prophet to his lips ere he rose to his feet. Then, calling to his servants, he said:

"Bring hither the treasure which Naaman brought with him from Damascus to reward Elisha."

"Nay, Naaman of Syria must take back with him to Damascus the treasure he did bring," said Elisha. "Elisha desireth not riches nor the praise of men. 'Twas not for these things that he didst heal Naaman of his leprosy."

Naaman, seeing that it would be quite useless to endeavor to force reward upon the prophet, signed to his servants to leave undisturbed the treasure. Then, again kneeling at Elisha's feet, he cried, aloud:

"Elisha, through thee it has been revealed to me that there is no god in all the earth but only in Israel. Henceforth, Naaman will offer sacrifice only to the true God of Israel."

"Peace be with thee, Naaman of Syria," said the prophet, with his sweet, gentle smile. "'Tis indeed well with thee. A greater good has come to thee than the healing of thy body from the foulness of leprosy. Go thou in peace."



CHAPTER VIII.

The days passed very slowly and wearily to Claudia, wife of Naaman, as she awaited in her palace home the return of her husband. Sometimes her heart was filled with hope, then, again, she would be plunged into the deepest despondency, when it seemed madness to believe that any man had power to heal the leper.

Leah, the little maid, watched her mistress wistfully, tenderly. One morning, as she sat at Claudia's feet, she looked up into her pale, beautiful face and said:

"Why art thou so sad, my dear mistress?"

"Ah, maiden," replied Claudia, "thou canst not understand the tortures of suspense which consume me."

"Suspense!" repeated the little maid. "Then thou dost doubt the power of Elisha to heal my lord of his leprosy?"

"Yes," answered Claudia. "For how can man be possessed of such power?"

A smile of rare sweetness lighted up the face of the little maid.

"My own dear mistress, put aside all thy doubts, all thy trouble, for my lord will return healed of his leprosy," she said.

"Child, great indeed is thy faith in this man, Elisha," said Claudia. "Hast thou ever seen him, spoken with him?"

"No," answered the little maid. "I was on my way to seek him when I was captured by the Syrians."

"What was thy purpose in seeking Elisha, maiden?" asked Claudia.

Leah's lips quivered, her soft eyes filled with tears.

"In the land of Israel I have a brother who has been a cripple from birth," she murmured. "I was on my way to Samaria to seek Elisha and beg of him that he heal my brother."

"But, child, thou art poor, how didst thou propose to reward Elisha for healing thy brother?" asked Claudia.

The little maid looked up inquiringly.

"What meaneth thou, dear mistress?" she asked.

"Surely thou knoweth, maiden, that the magicians of the court of Benhadad, king of Syria, receive rich salaries," replied Claudia. "But even they possess not the power of this Elisha for they cannot heal the leper. Therefore, Elisha must be even more richly rewarded than are the magicians of Benhadad's court."

"Dear mistress, Elisha is no magician, but a holy man of God," said the little maid. "He dwelleth not at the court of the king, neither does he receive aught in recompense for the good that he doeth."

"I—I do not understand," murmured Claudia, perplexedly. "Why, Naaman, my husband, did take with him to Samaria ten talents of silver, six thousand pieces of gold and ten changes of raiment with which to reward Elisha should he be healed of his leprosy."

Leah smiled.

"My lord will bring back with him from Damascus the ten talents of silver, the six thousand pieces of gold and the ten changes of raiment," she said, "for Elisha will have none of them."

Claudia sat for some moments in thought.

"Perhaps this Elisha is a seeker after fame, and so to win the praise of men he uses his power for the poor as well as the rich," she said, at length. "But I believe not that he will refuse the treasure which my husband carried with him to Samaria."

Leah did not answer. Claudia, after regarding her attentively for some moments, said:

"Thou seemeth to give no heed to my words, maiden. Dost thou in truth believe that Elisha will refuse to receive the treasure which Naaman carryeth with him?"

"I know dear mistress, that Elisha will refuse to accept the treasure which my lord carryeth with him to Samaria," replied the little maid, firmly. "Elisha careth not for riches nor the praise of men. He seeketh only to please and serve the Lord who hath given to him his great power."

"What manner of man is this Elisha who can inspire such great and unswerving faith?" mused Claudia. "Is the God of Israel more powerful than the god of Syria, for Rimmon hath given to no man in Syria power like unto that possessed by Elisha?" she said aloud.

The little maid looked up earnestly into her mistress' beautiful face.

"There is no God save the God of Israel," she said.

Claudia smiled indulgently.

"Thou art of the land of Israel, little one," she said, "and, therefore, thou dost believe that the God Israel worships be the only true God. Perhaps, if thou dwelleth long in Syria, thou will learn to worship Syria's god."

"No, dear lady, that could never be," replied Leah, earnestly. "I may see no more my people and my country, but I shall ever remain faithful to my God. He dwelleth not alone in the land of Israel, but he ruleth over all the earth. 'Tis He, Who through his prophet, will heal thy husband of his leprosy."

"Thou speaketh idle words child," said Claudia, a little impatiently. "The God of Israel would not bestow His favors upon a Syrian who does worship Syria's god. But, there, enough of this; let us speak of other things. Tell me of thy people. Hast thou brothers and sisters in the land of Israel?"

"I have but one brother, dear mistress," replied Leah.

"And this brother has been a cripple from birth?" gently asked Claudia.

"Yes, dear mistress."

"And thou dost love him very dearly?"

"Ah, so dearly," murmured the little maid, with quivering lips.

"Poor child, thy young life has known much sorrow," said Claudia, pityingly. "And, yet, thou thinketh more of the sorrows of others than of thy own."

"My heart is sad at times," said Leah. "But I must not rebel against the will of the good God."

"And is this why thou dost bear so patiently and uncomplainingly the sorrows which have darkened thy young life?" asked Claudia, wonderingly. "But the gods are wont to send afflictions upon those who offend them, thou canst not have offended thy God."

"God, in His wisdom, doth often afflict those whom He loveth," said Leah.

Claudia smiled.

"This God of thine is a strange God," she said.



CHAPTER IX.

When fourteen days had passed since his departure for Samaria, the caravan of Naaman again entered the gates of Damascus.

The little maid, learning of this, made haste to seek her mistress.

"Dear mistress," she said, "the caravan of my lord has entered the city and proceedeth to the palace of Benhadad, the king."

Claudia turned very white.

"And—and what other tidings dost thou bring?" she faltered. "Speak, child; keep me not in suspense."

"I bring no further tidings, my mistress," answered the little maid.

Claudia sank upon a couch, trembling and faint. Leah knelt beside her and kissed her hands.

"Why dost thou tremble and grow pale, dear mistress," she asked. "I did come to thee at once with the tidings of my lord's return, thinking that thou wouldst rejoice and be happy."

"If I knew that he were healed then indeed would I rejoice," said Claudia. "But if he be not healed my heart will be filled with sadness and sad indeed our meeting."

"Be at peace, my lady," said the little maid, earnestly. "My lord has returned healed of his leprosy."

"Thou hast indeed great faith, child," said Claudia, with a faint smile. "But only when I hear from the lips of my husband that he is healed will I believe. But, come and array me, for whether Naaman return in sorrow or gladness I will do him honor."

The little maid hastened to put a rich silken robe upon her mistress, binding back her golden hair with a circlet of glittering gems.

"Come," then said Claudia, "thou shalt await with me the coming of Naaman."

Upon entering Damascus, Naaman had at once sought the palace of the king.

The latter received him most graciously, saying:

"What fortune did attend thy journey into the land of Israel, my good Naaman?"

"My lord, I return healed of my leprosy," replied Naaman.

"Thou cometh indeed with wonderful tidings," exclaimed the king. "Marvelous is the power of this magician of the court of Jehoram. What sayeth thy wife, the beautiful Claudia? great rejoicing must indeed be hers."

"She as yet knows not that I have returned from Samaria," answered Naaman. "I did first seek the presence of my king to make known to him the wonders that have been done unto me."

"Ah," murmured Benhadad, "thou art ever faithful to thy country and thy king."

The proud eyes of the Syrian wavered and fell under the king's kind gaze.

"Ah," he was thinking, "the king knows not that I have forsaken the god of my country for Jehovah Who ruleth over all the earth."

"I will detain thee no longer at present," said Benhadad. "Make haste to the presence of thy wife with thy tidings of joy. Meanwhile the news shall go abroad over all the land that Naaman has returned from Samaria healed of his leprosy that all Syria may rejoice and offer sacrifice to Rimmon. Say to thy wife that Benhadad rejoices with her that Naaman has returned healed."

Naaman bent his head to kiss the hand of the king and then left the palace. As the chariot passed through the streets of Damascus shouts of rejoicing were heard upon every side; Benhadad had already sent forth the tidings of the healing of Naaman.

Claudia, awaiting the coming of her husband, heard the shouts and cries and turned very pale.

"What means those cries?" she asked of the little maid.

"My lord passes through the streets of Damascus and the people rejoices that he is healed," answered Leah.

"Only when I hear from the lips of my husband that he be healed will I believe," again said Claudia.

The servants of the palace then took up the joyous cries; Naaman had passed through the gates.

A few moments more and the embroidered draperies were put aside and Naaman stood upon the threshold of the great chamber. And as she looked into his face Claudia knew how it was with him. She moved forward and was folded to his breast. And the little maid, with tears in her eyes, passed out of the chamber, leaving them alone.

After a little while, however, she was summoned to the presence of Naaman. Claudia, her beautiful face all aglow with happiness, stood by her husband's side.

"Maiden," said Naaman, "Elisha, whose great powers thou didst make known to me, has healed me of my leprosy."

"My lord, my heart is indeed glad that thou hast returned healed of thy leprosy," said the little maid.

"And thou, maiden, shall be rewarded," continued Naaman. "Ask of me what thou wilt and it shall be granted unto thee."

The little maid fell upon her knees at his feet.

"O, my lord," she cried, "I would return to those who love me and sorrow for me in the dear land of Israel. I crave of thee but one thing, my lord—freedom."

"It is granted thee," said Naaman. "Thou art no more a slave."

The little maid caught his hand and covered it with kisses. Claudia stooped and lifted her to her feet.

"It grieves me to part with thee, little one," she said. "But I shall be glad that thou art happy with those whom thou dost love."

"I shall never forget thee nor cease to love thee," murmured Leah.

"Maiden, hast thou no further desire?" asked Naaman.

"What more could I desire, my lord, since thou hast given me my freedom?" replied the little maid.

"Thou art poor," said Naaman. "Hast thou never craved riches?"

"Not for myself, my lord," answered Leah. "But I have often wished that my parents were not forced to labor so hard."

"Thy parents shall labor no more," said Naaman, quietly.

"What meaneth thou, my lord?" murmured the little maid, bewilderedly.

"Listen to me, maiden," continued Naaman. "I did carry with me to Samaria ten talents of silver, six thousand pieces of gold and ten changes of raiment with which to reward Elisha should he heal me of my leprosy."

Leah smiled.

"And Elisha did refuse to accept the treasure which thou didst carry with thee to Samaria," she said.

"Yes," replied Naaman, "but the treasure which Elisha did refuse shall be thine."



CHAPTER X.

Early upon the morning following a servant came to Leah and said:

"There be a lad outside the gates of the palace who desires speech with thee."

"A lad desires speech with me," said the little maid, wonderingly. "But I know no lad in Damascus."

"He inquired for the Israelite maiden who is a slave in the house of Naaman," replied the servant. "'Tis only a ragged beggar lad," and the servant turned scornfully away.

Leah passed out of the palace and ran down to the great gates.

Beyond the gates, for the servant had not permitted him to enter, stood a lad. His coarse garments were soiled and torn, his bare feet were cut and bleeding. The golden light from the rising sun fell upon his dark curly head.

Uttering a cry of joy, he ran, with outstretched hands, towards the little maid.

"Leah! sister! I have found thee at last!" he cried.

She stood motionless, gazing at him with wide, bewildered eyes.

"Isaac! my brother! is it indeed thou?" she cried.

"Yes, 'tis indeed thy Isaac!" he answered. "But, as thou dost see, no longer a cripple for Elisha has made me whole."

"Elisha has made thee whole," she repeated.

"Yes; listen, and I will tell thee all," said Isaac. "I will speak but briefly of the sorrow which did fill our hearts when thou wert captured by the Syrians. Had I not been a helpless cripple I would have gone forth to seek thee. Then one day our mother called our father to her and said, 'Unless

thou seeketh help we shall soon have no child, for Isaac will die of his grief for his sister.' 'Where and of whom shall I seek help?' asked our father. 'Journey to Samaria and seek the prophet, Elisha,' answered our mother. 'Tell to him how heavily the hand of misfortune has fallen upon our home. Beg of him to return with thee and heal our son.'

"So upon the morrow our father did borrow the ass of our neighbor and set forth upon his journey to Samaria. In the evening he returned, bringing Elisha with him. That night, sister, while our parents slept, Elisha came and stood beside my couch. I felt the touch of his hand upon my limbs and I heard his voice saying, 'With the sun thou shalt rise from thy couch and walk.' Then he was gone and it seemed to me I had but dreamed. When the morning had come and the sun had risen, Elisha was gone, but I did arise from my couch and walk, for I was strong and made whole.

"Then did I set forth to seek thee. I was many days in reaching Damascus. I was often hungry and footsore, but I was happy for I was no longer a cripple. But yesterday I did pass through the gates of Damascus. There was great excitement upon the streets. The people were shouting and uttering cries of joy. I learned that they were rejoicing because Naaman, a great Syrian general and favorite of the king, Benhadad, had returned from Samaria healed of his leprosy.

"I asked a woman in the crowd who had healed Naaman. 'A great man called Elisha,' she replied. 'Tis said that Naaman did hear of this Elisha through a little Israelite maid who is a slave in Naaman's household.' Oh, dear sister, how I did rejoice at her words for I knew then that I had found thee. I am come to offer myself as Naaman's slave that I may ransom thee."

Leah put her arms tenderly about his neck.

"Brother," she said, "I am no more a slave; neither shalt thou nor our parents labor, for Naaman has made me rich. Oh! dear brother! our hearts should indeed be filled with gratitude to Jehovah, Israel's God."

END.





Transcriber's Notes:

Obvious punctuation errors repaired.

Page 12, "widsom" changed to "wisdom" (words of wisdom)

Page 52, "pesisted" changed to "persisted" (persisted the servant)

Page 68, "A" changed to "An" (An hour before)

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MAID OF ISRAEL ***

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